Construction began immediately in January 1948 with engineer-in-chief Karnail Singh at the helm of what was to be a formidable assignment.

By the time it was complete, the 228.5-km-long Assam Rail Link Project (ARLP) cost about Rs 93 million and took less than two years to complete, opening for passenger traffic on 26 January 1950.

Reconnaissance

The best way to establish a connection was by linking the metre-gauge lines of the Oudh and Tirhut Railway with the Assam Railway. This meant connecting Kishanganj in Bihar with Amingaon in Assam. The project was divided into four key sectors. Surveys were conducted – first by air and then on the ground – before work commenced. The lines ran through Bihar's Purnea district for about 64 km, West Bengal's Darjeeling and Jalpaiguri districts for 125.5 km, and Cooch Behar for 8 km, and Assam's Goalpara district for about 35 km.

Given the lack of time and the seemingly impossible deadline, surveys were quick but quite promptly revealed several potential problems, including bridging the Rivers Tista and Torsa. Weather played a huge role as the monsoon, the surveyors realized, lasted for more than six months in the region. The deadline for the completion of the project was January 1950. This left engineers 11 months of working time.

Easier said than done

The first step was replacing, and not converting, the 190-km, 2 ft-gauge line between Kishanganj and Siliguri into metre gauge as it was laid like a tram line. This section came under the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway (DHR), so in October 1948, the Indian Government bought the DHR's main line and its extensions, handing its operations over to the ARLP. This was one of the easier problems to solve.

The second section proved more complicated. The 35-km stretch between the Siliguri junction and Gish Bridge near Bagrakote, both in West Bengal, required bridging many small streams and rivers. However, it was the one over the Tista, a tributary of the Brahmaputra, which proved the most challenging. One of the most turbulent rivers in